

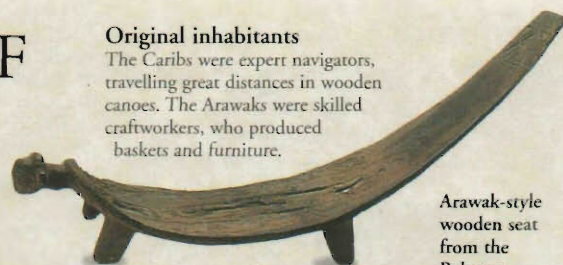
CARIBBEAN, HISTORY OF



FOR CENTURIES, the Caribbean islands were home to the Carib and Arawak peoples. Their way of life was abruptly disturbed when Europeans arrived in the 1490s. Within 100 years, most had been wiped out by new European rulers who brought thousands of Africans into the Caribbean to work on sugar plantations. The sugar-based economy continued until its decline in the late 19th century. From the mid-1960s, the islands gradually gained independence from European control.

Original inhabitants

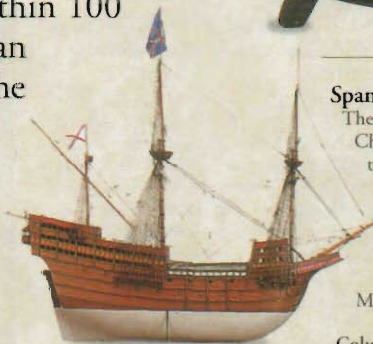
The Caribs were expert navigators, travelling great distances in wooden canoes. The Arawaks were skilled craftworkers, who produced baskets and furniture.



Arawak-style wooden seat from the Bahamas

Spanish conquest

The arrival of the Spanish-sponsored navigator Christopher Columbus in the Caribbean in 1492 transformed the region. Convoys of galleons laden with gold and other treasures from the Spanish empire in South America soon crossed the sea on their way back to Spain. Within a few years, Spanish armies had conquered and settled almost every island. Most of the Caribs were killed by the invaders.



Columbus's ship, the *Santa Maria*

European settlement

In the 16th century, with unofficial government backing, English, French, and Dutch pirates raided Spanish treasure ships. They also captured many of the smaller islands. Settlers from Europe arrived, and by 1750, most of the islands were under British, French, or Dutch rule.



Toussaint L'Ouverture

Ex-slave Toussaint L'Ouverture (1743–1803) led a revolt of slaves in French-ruled Haiti in the 1790s. He declared the country a republic, but the French regained control and took him to France, where he died.



Plantations

Europeans set up plantations to satisfy demand for sugar and tobacco in Europe. African slaves worked on the plantations. By 1750, the Caribbean produced most of the world's sugar.



Slave trade

Most of the Caribbean slave trade was controlled from English ports. Ships left England for West Africa with goods to barter for slaves. The slaves were shipped across the Atlantic. Sugar, tobacco, and other crops were then taken back to England for sale.

Rastafarians

Many Jamaicans are Rastafarians. They believe that the last emperor of Ethiopia, Ras Tafari, or Haile Selassie, was the new messiah who would lead his people back to Africa.



Cuban War

In 1895, following an earlier, unsuccessful uprising, the Cubans rose in revolt against their Spanish rulers. In 1898, the USA declared war on Spain, and freed Cuba.

Emigration

After World War II, many people left the Caribbean in search of work and a better standard of living in Europe. In 1948, the *Empire Windrush* took 492 emigrants from Kingston, Jamaica to London, UK. Over the next 20 years, thousands of Caribbean islanders emigrated to Britain.



Fidel Castro

In 1959, Fidel Castro (b.1927) became the President of Cuba and introduced many social reforms. The US government tried to depose him in 1961, and he turned to the USSR for help. When Soviet nuclear missiles were installed in Cuba in 1962, the world came close to nuclear war.

Timeline

1300s Caribs drive out Arawak people from the eastern Caribbean islands.

1492 Christopher Columbus lands in the Bahamas.

1500s The Spanish take control of the Caribbean.

1700s French, British, Dutch, and Danes capture many islands.

1804 Haiti becomes first Caribbean island to achieve independence from European rule.

1898–1902 Cuba under rule of USA.

1933 Fulgencio Batista becomes ruler of Cuba.

1948 *Empire Windrush* takes first emigrants to Britain.

Capturing a slave



1959 Cuban Revolution; Fidel Castro takes power.

1962 Cuban missile crisis brings the USA and the USSR to the brink of nuclear war.

1962 Jamaica becomes the first British Caribbean colony to win independence.

1962–83 Most British islands win independence; Dutch and French islands remain tied to Europeans.

1983 USA overthrows left-wing regime in Grenada.



Flag of Jamaica

1994 USA intervenes to secure democracy in Haiti, after years of dictatorship on the island.

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